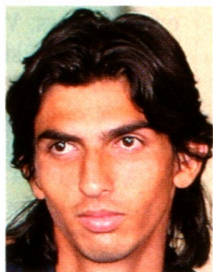


INDIA'S MEGA EARNERS

M.S. DHONI
(CHENNAI)
(\$1.5m)
Rs 6 crore



ISHANT SHARMA
(KOLKATA)
(\$950,000)
Rs 3.8 crore



IRFAN PATHAN
(MOHALI)
(\$925,000)
Rs 3.7 crore

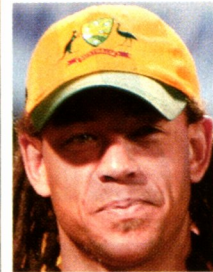


HARBHAJAN SINGH
(MUMBAI)
(\$800,000)
Rs 3.2 crore



FOREIGN BIG FISH

ANDREW SYMONDS
(HYDERABAD)
(\$1.35m)
Rs 5.4 crore



SANATH JAYASURIYA
(MUMBAI)
(\$975,000)
Rs 3.9 crore



Players are auctioned for 59 matches in 44 days. A player will play a minimum of 14 and a maximum of 16 matches. contracted by BCCI.

Now that the fainting fits have passed, what transpired in the Hilton Towers in Mumbai was cricket's first—and probably last—auction. Much, including the rules, may change at the end of IPL's first three-year cycle. Auctioneer Madley of Briths Dreweatts, a carpet specialist, whose experiences with cricket auctions have involved Bradman and Jack Hobbs' bats, reckoned it would take six hours to get through 79 "lots". Given that these lots were people and there was a media contingent of around 200 waiting to be fed regular information, it took nine.

The atmosphere inside the auction room was controlled but cordial, an unusual cast of characters, including two former captains in Ganguly and Dravid, movie stars, and a business tycoon, trying to outwit each other and balance their books peering into computers and scribbling notes. This was cricket selection, accountancy and auctioneering all rolled into one. As the bids leapt over their reserve prices the man behind IPL, BCCI vice-president Lalit Modi looked even more pleased with himself at every successive appearance before the cameras.

When it was done, each of the eight teams believed they had the players they wanted barring a handful and that the others had spent too much or too lopsidedly. "Mohali a pretty team, but it's got no backbone," said a rival. Mukesh Ambani's Mumbai exhausted half their cap of \$5 million at the end of the first two rounds in going after big names mentioned on a list drawn up by icon Tendulkar. Jaipur, on the other

hand, bid below the minimum \$3.3 million, and had to put their deficit of \$375,000 into IPL pool as a penalty.

In order to get to the auction room with something like a plan, teams were scrambling until D-day morning. Some had put in all-night meetings the night before and walked into the Hilton on the back of three hours of sleep, coffee and blind faith. The more organised sought to tap every resource, cover every base which included talking to ex-cricketers, game theory experts, number crunchers, software programmers, statisticians, marketing men, agents and cricket media about how to get the right men for the right price. If Ambani's Mumbai put its in-house pool of cricketers on the job, Vijay Mallya's

Bangalore team ran mock in-house auctions. CEO designate Charu Sharma said, "It gave us a sense of how out of control situations could get." They went into the auction feeling calm, with captain Rahul Dravid (who Sharma said was, "in it to the neck") supplying inside knowledge to bid for low-glamour but high utility names.

Shah Rukh Khan hosted the Kolkata franchise's backroom team at his home two nights running, working through the early hours of the morning, with Shoaib Akhtar dropping in for a visit. On a brief stop over in Mumbai with teammate Younis Khan, the Pakistani speed devil (or given his disciplinary record, speed trap) was visible and audible, having friendly chats with IPL bosses to inform them that the breakaway Zee-backed Indian Cricket League was offering him \$5 million to sign up. It didn't work and Akhtar was bought by the Kolkata franchise at a modest salary of \$425,000.

In between winning the Mohali franchise and bidding for players, Bollywood star Preity Zinta is said to have been swotting up on the difference between zooter and sliders. She turned up for the auction in a fetching red dress, sitting alongside boyfriend and franchise partner Ness Wadia. When they won the bid for flaky Indian pacesman Sreesanth, the couple celebrated by going into a delighted clinch.

During the auction, Modi once tried to control a heaving press room with 50 jostling photographers trying to get a shot of Zinta. He turned from the self-satisfied IPL patriarch into tetchy school master trying to keep the order by threatening to leave the room. The

ICON INCOME

SACHIN TENDULKAR

\$1.12m: Rs 4.48 crore

RAHUL DRAVID

\$1.03m: Rs 4.12 crore

YUVRAJ SINGH

\$1.06m: Rs 4.24 crore

SOURAV GANGULY

\$1.09m: Rs 4.36 crore

VIRENDER SEHWAG

\$862,000: Rs 3.44 crore